

especially one that he owns. He may also be slightly embarrassed about being “in trade” or about the kind of work his family business does. He may have gotten a degree in philosophy and now may find himself far removed from the concerns of a metal recycler or chain of self-service laundries. He may regard the family business as a bit unworthy, or even unattractive. But attitudes are subtle, infectious, and insidious. The polished cynic may be able to deprecate himself and the business with which he is associated while still doing his best to make it better. But lower down—among the young, the hourly employees, and the real cynics—people will become sour, dissatisfied with themselves and their work. The business will suffer.

It is all right to joke. And it is probably a good idea not to take yourself too seriously. But work is serious. Family members should be taught to respect the source of their wealth and to be willing to do all they can to support it.

If your family is not involved in a family business, think about the common occupations your family is involved in. Maybe you come from a line of farmers, lawyers, or doctors. Or a family of blacksmiths or college professors. Whatever these common occupations are, they are an important source of family identity.

THE FAMILY BUSINESS

The family business is a huge cultural asset, as well as the most important financial asset. Its identity should be an extension of your family’s identity. The more your kids or grandkids—and your cousins, nieces, and nephews—get involved on some level in the family business, the stronger that part of your family culture will be.

Like it or not, you spend a lot of your time working. Your career is a big part of who you are. A few centuries ago, people recognized this by naming themselves after their professions. Blacksmiths were given the last name “Smith.” Millers were called “Miller,” and so on.

But beyond that, the following are a part of the family identity:

- Niche business know-how.
- Business infrastructure developed by previous generations.